BOONE · BLOWING ROCK · BANNER ELK · VALLE CRUCIS

High Country Investment Property Guide

A local investor's framework for buying, renting, and building long-term wealth in the High Country—with an honest look at what actually works in today's market.

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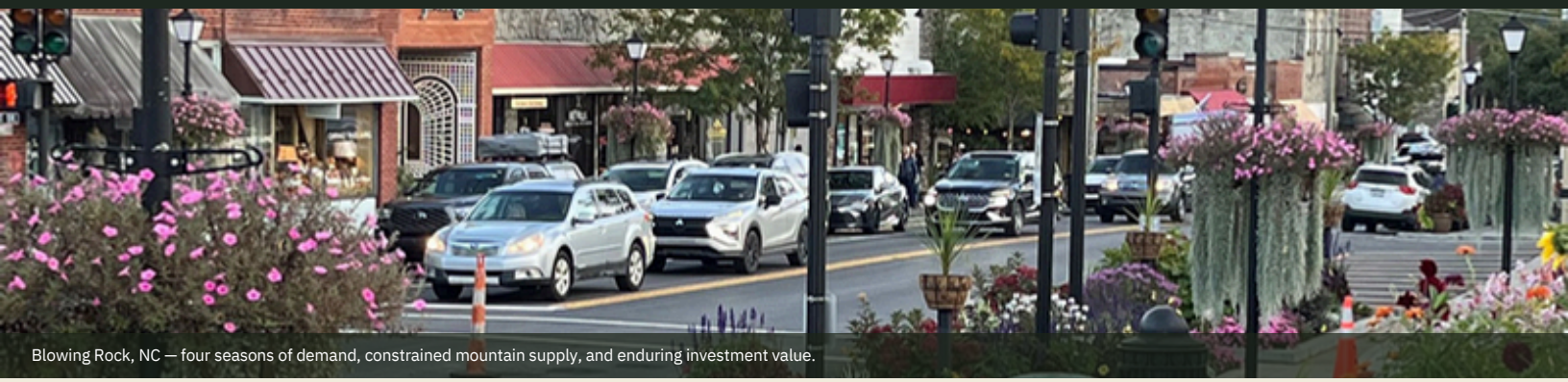


Blowing Rock, NC — four seasons of demand, constrained mountain supply, and enduring investment value.

Why Invest in the High Country?

TheNC High Country offers a rare combination: strong year-roundrentaldemand from 21,000+ App State students, four-season visitor traffic, naturally constrained land supply, and sustained long-term appreciation. This market rewards patient, locally-informed investors — and punishes those who buy on emotion alone.

21,000+	3	$1,000–$1,400	3,300+ ft
APP STATE STUDENTS	NEARBY SKI RESORTS	PER BR/MO · 2026	AVERAGE ELEVATION

CHAPTER 1 Three Investment Profiles — What Actually Works

PROFILE 1 — RECOMMENDED

Long-Term Rental Near App State

Predictable income, low turnover, and no platform dependency. The STR market is saturated — long-term rents are more reliable.

- 3–5 BR houses rented by the room
- $1,000–$1,400/BR/mo in 2026
- 4BR = $4,400+/mo gross revenue
- Aug–Jul leases; academic-year demand
- Gross yield: 7–10% in good locations

PROFILE 2 — PROCEED WITH CAUTION

Short-Term Vacation Rental (STR)

High potential but saturated market. Regulations tightening. Requires active management.

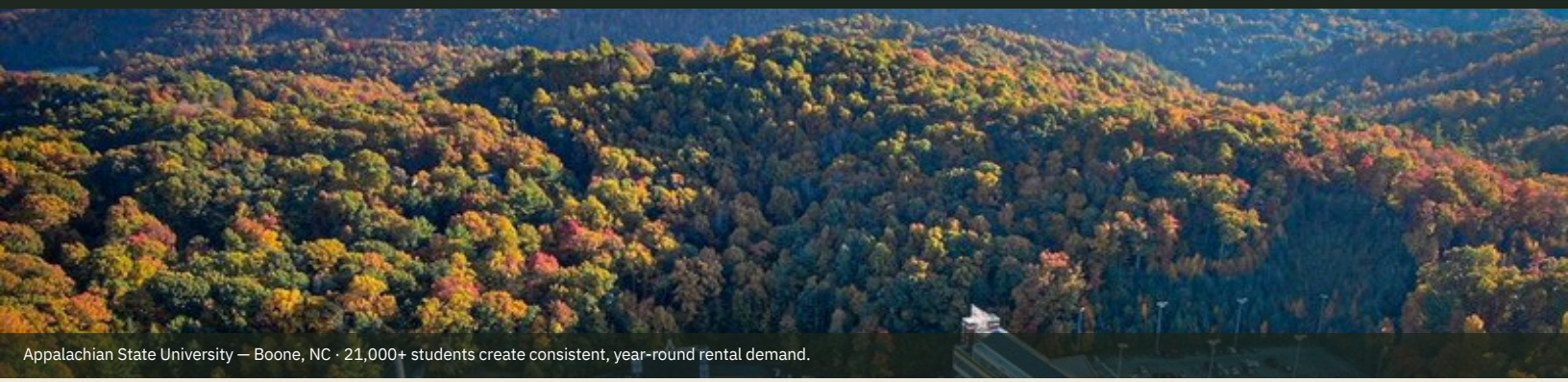
- Peak: Oct, Dec–Mar, Jun–Aug
- Verify STR regs before you buy
- Mgmt fees: 20–30% of gross
- Many markets now oversupplied
- Income less predictable than LTR

PROFILE 3

Long-Term Appreciation Hold

Mountains can't be endlessly subdivided. Constrained supply creates a structural floor under prices.

- Blowing Rock & Banner Elk corridors
- Creekfront and ridgeline properties
- View lots with strict covenants
- Best for 5–10+ year horizon



Appalachian State University — Boone, NC · 21,000+ students create consistent, year-round rental demand.

CHAPTER 2 Long-Term Rentals — The Smarter Play Right Now

Why the STR Market is Saturated — and Long-Term Wins

TheHighCountrySTR marketexploded post-2020. Every investorwith a mountain cabinjumpedon Airbnb. The result: in many communities, supply has outpaced demand, nightly rates have compressed, and occupancy is down from peak years. Meanwhile, long-term rental demand from App State's 21,000+ students has never wavered.

- **Predictable income:** 12-month leases mean no seasonal gaps, no platform algorithm changes, no surprise slow weeks.
- **Lower operating costs:** No furnishing, no cleaning between stays, no Airbnb fees, no constant marketing.
- **Less management burden:** One tenant vs. 150 check-ins per year.
- **Regulatory stability:** LTR properties face far less municipal scrutiny than STRs, which are increasingly regulated.
- **Consistent yield:** At $1,000–$1,400/BR/mo in 2026, a 4BR house near campus generates $48,000–$67,000/yr gross revenue — reliably, every year.

BEST LONG-TERM RENTAL LOCATIONS

- **Rivers St / Stadium Dr:** Highest demand, fastest to lease, premium per-BR rents.
- **Faculty St / Deerfield:** Quieter, strong demand, slightly lower rents but less turnover.
- **On AppalCART routes:** Expands your tenant pool significantly. See all 13 free routes here.
- **Within 0.5 mile of campus:** Commands top-tier rents year after year.

WHAT TO BUY FOR LTR

- **3–5 BR houses:** Each bedroom is revenue. Sweet spot for student rentals.
- **Townhomes & condos:** Lower maintenance; HOA rules permitting.
- **Off-street parking:** Commands premium rent — students with cars pay more.
- **In-unit laundry:** Reduces turnover and commands higher rents.
- **Buy by June:** Gives you time to lease for August — don't miss the window.

> *I've helped dozens of investors buy near App State. The ones who chose long-term rentals over STR have had far more consistent returns and far fewer headaches. Call me to run the numbers for your specific situation: 770.639.1233*

King Street · Downtown Boone, NC

Appalachian State University campus

CHAPTER 3 Due Diligence — What to Check Before You Buy

ITEM	WHY IT MATTERS FOR MOUNTAIN INVESTMENT
Zoning	Confirm rental permissions with Town of Boone Planning or Watauga County Planning.
Septic / Well	Many mountain properties are on private systems — inspect and test both before closing.
HOA Rules	Some communities prohibit rentals or limit lease terms. Read all covenants thoroughly.
Flood / Slope	Check FEMA flood maps and slope stability for creek-adjacent or steep-lot properties.
Seasonal Access	Verify year-round road access. Some private roads become impassable in winter.
Insurance	Mountain investment properties may need wind/hail riders. Budget $2,000–4,000/yr.
Cap Rate	Net operating income ÷ purchase price. Target 6%+ for residential rental in this market.

CHAPTER 4 Financing + Key Resources

LOAN TYPES

- **Conventional investment:** 20–25% down; rates 0.5–1% above primary.
- **Vacation home loan:** Occupy 14+ days/yr for better second-home terms.
- **DSCR loans:** Qualify based on rental income — good for LTR investors.
- **Local lenders:** Boone community banks know mountain properties.
- **1031 Exchange:** Defer capital gains into High Country real estate.

KEY LINKS

→ Town of Boone Planning & Zoning
→ Watauga County Planning
→ AppalCART Route Maps (all 13 free routes)
→ Student Housing Playbook — http://plyler.realtor
→ Boone Zoning Map & Ordinances
→ Email Andrew — aplyler@brri.net

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Blue Ridge Realty & Investments · Boone, NC 28607 Deep High Country roots · 40+ years local life · App State alumnus Specializing in investment properties, long-term rentals, & mountain real estate
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